



**UNIVERSITÀ DEGLI STUDI
DI CAGLIARI**

COARA ACTION PLAN 2024-2027

University of Cagliari - UNICA



HR EXCELLENCE IN RESEARCH

1.

**Introduction,
research
strategy and
commitments**



About the University of Cagliari

The [University of Cagliari \(UNICA\)](#)¹ is a research University, the largest HE Institution in Sardinia, Italy. As a public Institution, given its geographic location, UNICA fulfills its societal responsibility through teaching, research and valorization/exploitation of research results, with a comprehensive multidisciplinary and interdisciplinary approach offering complete education and research training on STEM, Biomedical and Humanities fields.

Characterized by the transdisciplinary nature of 15 research Departments, UNICA is committed to support research through strengthening international collaborations, researchers' mobility, attractivity and retention of the talented scholars, as well as participation in European research networks, forefront of institutional commitment to pursue ERA policy, as witnessed by the strategic plan of the Institution and the award in 2024 of the [HR Excellence in Research](#)² label by the European Commission for the implementation of the European Charter for Researchers principles.

Furthermore, assessment of research quality and impact as well as researchers' performance and recruitment are at the core of UNICA strategic policy framework.

UNICA Research Strategy

The [2022-2027 strategic plan](#)³ has been drawn up, with a commitment to continuous improvement and on the basis of the quality system adopted by UNICA, considering all the University's internal and external stakeholders, especially those connected to the scientific community including academic and administrative staff, early stage and senior researchers, civil society, local, national and international institutions.

¹ Home page | University of Cagliari

² <https://www.unica.it/it/internazionale/hrs4r-strategy>

³ https://web.unica.it/unica/it/ateneo_s09_ss01_sss02_ssss03.page

Commitments

UNICA believes that a reform of research assessment is needed to align the Italian system to the ERA policy; in fact, the current selection criteria and career system require new efforts and some corrective measures to improve the evaluation systems for research assessment, as already adopted by other international research systems.

Institutions, Research Performing and Research Funding Organizations at an international level have long been searching for new criteria that can enhance and reward the quality of research. Common points of discussion include (but are not limited to) the development of new indicators that go beyond quantitative indicators and recognizing criteria such as open science, valorization of research results, research impact, equal opportunities, quality and transparency.

With this belief, in 2022 UNICA joined the initiative [“Coalition for Advancing of Research Evaluation \(CoARA\)”](#)⁴ and signed the [Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment \(ARRA\)](#)⁵. UNICA agrees on the need to reform research assessment practices, specifically considering research quality, ethics, accountability, fairness and impact. Research assessment should consider both appropriate qualitative and quantitative indicators via peer review for all disciplines.

Based on that, UNICA plans its own strategies to recruit and reward best researchers, to support early researchers in the development of their research career, and to offer a vibrant research environment counteracting discrimination. To these aims, UNICA signed the [“San Francisco Declaration on Research Assessment”](#)⁶ (DORA) recognizing and embracing the need towards a reform of the research assessment system improving the ways in which researchers and the outputs of scholarly research are evaluated.

The present document (considered as a living document) represents the commitment and agenda of the University of Cagliari for implementing the CoARA strategy in the light of the ARRA principles in the next year framework 2024-2027, considers synergies with previous commitments of the Institution for the HRS4R strategy implementation to support the careers of researchers.

⁴ About - CoARA

⁵ The Agreement - CoARA

⁶ <https://sfdora.org/>

2.

UNICA action plan for CoARA



2. UNICA action plan for CoARA

ARRA PRINCIPLE	IMPLEMENTATION IN UNICA	Accomplished by
Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research	According to the OTM-R standards, the following experiences and achievements will be properly considered in any recruitment regulation: • cooperation with foreign and international organizations and research centers; • teaching at foreign Universities or highly qualified international research centers, even considering virtual mobility experiences; • achievement of international awards.	2025
	UniCa will plan workshops and seminars tailored for researchers' training needs, according to seniority level and experience, as well as their continuity and refinement on the basis of audience participation and feedback.	2027
	UniCa will organize training courses for all researchers (R1-R4) on research integrity, intellectual property rights, ethics, professional attitude, and data management to increase awareness over professional responsibility.	2027
Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators	UniCa will define a standard procedure for evaluating and monitoring the progress of research outcomes for recognised researchers (R2).	2026
	UniCa will elaborate guidelines for researchers on how to manage and store research data, in compliance with the GDPR, FAIR principles, responsible research and innovation principles, and societal engagement.	2025

2. UNICA action plan for CoARA

ARRA PRINCIPLE	IMPLEMENTATION IN UNICA	Accomplished by
Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index	An initial pilot project will involve three UniCa Departments, on a voluntary basis, testing the mentorship programme by formally assigning a senior researcher or expert to R2 and/or R3 researchers depending on Department priorities. The mentors will provide career guidance by designing a personalized career development plan (PCDP), which should include training needs, research progress monitoring, mobility phases.	2026
Avoid the use of rankings of research organizations in research assessment	Although Unica participates in rankings, it will not use them to allocate resources or to determine the career progression of its researchers.	
Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organizational changes committed to	Provide administrative support to researchers in drafting the data management plans requested by European projects.	2026
	Increase the budget assigned to the Quality, Library Services and Museums Division with additional resources to support Open Access (OA) publications.	2025
	Implement an integrated Public Engagement communication plan including the information regarding the public engagement and, more generally speaking, the third mission.	2025
	If not already included in the position's funding, provide a starting grant to R3 researchers.	2026

2. UNICA action plan for CoARA

ARRA PRINCIPLE	IMPLEMENTATION IN UNICA	Accomplished by
Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes	Developing a standard procedure that applies to all doctoral programmes, which will focus on evaluating and monitoring the research progress of R1 researchers.	2024
	Update of the Code of Ethics and Conduct by including a commitment to prevent unconscious biases by members of selection committees, as requested by its GEP. Upon members' acceptance of the appointment within the selection committees, make them declare that they have read the Code of Ethics and Conduct and the articles of reference.	2024
Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use	Training activities organized by a UniCa multi-disciplinary team for the Faculty staff with managerial positions to develop management, organizational and mentoring skills. Participation in these activities should be mandatory for Faculty members in relevant management positions (e.g., department Heads, PhD coordinators, and supervisors) to ensure good supervision quality.	2027
	UniCa will organize initiatives (seminars, workshops) on the thematic of results dissemination and exploitation, and on public engagement to enhance the awareness of researchers also on the ARRA principles.	2027

2. UNICA action plan for CoARA

ARRA PRINCIPLE	IMPLEMENTATION IN UNICA	Accomplished by
Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition	Appointment of the Open Science Committee in charge of the development and adoption of an academic open science policy.	2024
	UniCa will organize initiatives (seminars, workshops) on the thematic of results dissemination and exploitation, and on public engagement to enhance the awareness of researchers.	2027
Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments	Create a section of the UniCa website to emphasize good practice in research.	2026
Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research	Draft of the OTM-R institutional policy and setting up a quality control system.	2025



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